

The Glorious Black Yamāri Tantra, King of Tantras, the Third Kalpa

Śrī Kṛṣṇa Yamāri Tantra Rāja Trikalpanāma · Toh 469 · Derge Kangyur

དཔལ་གཤམ་རྒྱུ་འདེན་གཤམ་པའོ་རྒྱ་ཀྱི་ལྷ་པོ་རྒྱ་གསུ་པ།

Toh 469 in the Kangyur is known in Sanskrit as the Śrī Kṛṣṇa Yamāri Tantra Rāja Trikalpanāma and in Tibetan as the Glorious Black Yamāri Tantra, King of Tantras, the Third Kalpa. It is a tantric text belonging to the class of Highest Yoga Tantra, focused on the wrathful deity Yamāri — the Black Yamāri — who is celebrated as the conqueror of Yama, the lord of death, and is understood in ultimate terms as an emanation of the dharmakāya. The text concerns ritual instructions for practitioners who have completed the approach practice, guiding them in the construction of a maṇḍala in a charnel ground or other secluded place and the performance of associated rites connected with Yamāri's wheel of activity. It was translated into Tibetan by the monk Vajragrapha in collaboration with the accomplished Indian paṇḍita Bāro Phyagdum, and it forms part of the broader cycle of Yamāri tantras preserved within the Kangyur.

Thus it is concluded.

This was translated from the presence of Bāro Phyagdum, the supreme Indian paṇḍita who attained the supreme accomplishment (siddhi), and by the Tibetan translator, the monk Vajragrapha.

In the Indian language: Śrī Kṛṣṇa Yamāri Tantra Rāja Trikalpanāma. In the Tibetan language: The Glorious Black Yamāri Tantra, King of Tantras, the Third Kalpa.

Homage to the Blessed One, the glorious Yamāri.

He who in ultimate truth is the dharmakāya, peaceful by nature,
Who here conquers the three realms,
And who is renowned as the Foe of Yama —
The ritual of turning his wheel is here explained.

A mantra practitioner endowed with qualities,
Having performed the approach practice according to the ritual,
Shall draw the maṇḍala in a charnel ground or other solitary place,
To a measure of one cubit on each side.

He shall cleanse it with the fivefold pure substances of fragrance
Together with sun, moon, and so forth.
The five sacred substances including cow and so on,
And also the feast-wheel offering,
And by the distinctions of inner and outer offerings
He shall make excellent worship.

He shall then begin to draw, assemble, arrange, mix, and transfer the wheel.
The mantra practitioner who possesses yoga
Shall face in the southern direction
And, recalling the samaya commitment,
While recollecting the secret mantra Om Vajra Samaya Stvaṃ,
Shall begin to draw the wheel.

From the center outward to a measure of sixteen finger-breadths,
Encircled all around in a circle —
This is the inner wheel.
Going around in three successive rings,
Sixteen gateless iron walls shall be made.
This is the city of Yama,
The point of entry for the three existences.

Outside it, three border-rings
Are encircled throughout with iron-grid patterns,
And on each of those border-rings
Thirty-two houses are beautifully arranged.

Having drawn this wheel — the wheel of beings moving according to the
Dharma —
On the outermost border-ring,
Beginning from the letter Ka and ending with the letter Da,
Excluding the letters Ña and Ña, these shall be placed.
Then, beginning from the letter Dha and ending with the letter Kṣa,
These shall be written in sequence after them.

On each of the middle border-rings
The sixteen vowels shall be placed in doubled form.

When one begins to assemble, place, and so forth,
These signs must be understood:
Moon, eye, quality,
Veda, arrow, faculty,

Ocean, auspiciousness, planet, direction,
Fierce, sun, limb, place —
These are well known to be called "date."

On the outermost border-ring,
Beginning from the eastern Brahmā-line,
From the house of the non-sequential planet,
One takes only the auspicious letter
And places it on the inner-facing edge of the border-ring
At the sides of the Brahmā-line,
Giving it to the four directions at the measure of one eye-space.

From the house of the non-sequential directional planet,
One takes the letter at the measure of one eye-space
And places it to the right and left of that in the east.

From the non-sequential auspicious house,
One takes the one bearing the second vowel,
Measures it at one eye-space,
And places one each on its respective face.

From the house bearing the ocean-sign, counted from the western
Brahmā-line,
One bearing the eleventh vowel is taken at the measure of one eye-space
And placed to the right and left of that in the southern direction.

From the non-sequential house of the west bearing the moon-sign,
One bearing the thirteenth vowel is taken at the measure of one eye-space
And placed in sequence on the southern face.

That same clear vowel is taken at the measure of one eye-space
And given to the western face as before.

From the auspicious house in the west,
One bearing the thirteenth vowel is taken at the measure of one eye-space
And likewise given to the western face.

From the auspicious house in the north,
One bearing the eleventh vowel is taken at the measure of one eye-space
And likewise given to the northern face.

What is called "the seed of wind,"
Taken at the measure of one eye-space, is placed in sequence.

What resides in the house of the arrow-sign, made as a ball of light,
And counted from that point, resides in the house of the planet-sign —

Those bearing the third vowel
Are taken at the measure of a moon-space
And given one by one at the northeast corner.

What resides in the house of the ocean-sign,
Those bearing the second vowel,
Taken from the auspicious house out of sequence,
At the measure of a moon-space —
Are likewise given at the southeast corner.

From the auspicious house out of sequence,
Those bearing the fifth vowel,
Taken from the house of the limbed-sign
At the measure of a moon-space —
Are likewise given at the southwest corner.

From the date-sign house out of sequence,
Those bearing the third vowel,
And from the auspicious house out of sequence,
Taken at the measure of a moon-space —
Are likewise given at the northwest corner.

Having arranged them thus,
One then proceeds to draw the lines.
Keeping the samaya (sacred pledge) in mind
And with the force of vajra (ritual power),
From both sides of the brahma-line of the east,
The paired letters are drawn out
And placed in the central house.

From the brahma-line sides of the other directions,
The paired letters are likewise drawn out
And equally placed in the central house.

Then the letters of the east again:
The second pair is drawn out
And placed in the house of the second sequence.
The same is done for the other directions.

The third pair of the east
Is drawn into the house of the third sequence.
The same is done for the other directions.

The corner letters that stand alone
Are drawn into their own interior corners.

Above the houses from which those were taken,
The vowel letters are to be drawn.
Upon the foundation of the vowel letters,
The name letters are to be drawn.
Upon the foundation of the name letters,
The action letters appropriate to each respective activity
Are to be placed.

For slaying, repelling, and separating,
The syllable PHAṬ is to be placed.
For suppressing, the syllable LAṂ.
For pacifying, the syllable OM̐.
For enriching, likewise the syllable SVĀ.
For subjugating, adorned with the syllable BHĀ.
For hooking, the syllable JAḤ.

The activity rays of light for these are:
Pacifying is water; enriching is earth.
Subjugating is wind; wrathful action is fire.
Separating, hooking, and repelling correspond to subjugating.
Suppressing corresponds to enriching.

Having completed the drawing procedure,
One then commences the combining procedure.

With the non-dual mantra,
The auspicious letter of the center
Is made into a ball of light like the moon.
The tenth, king of mantras,
Is placed inside that ball of light
As the desired object to be accomplished.
At its very center, one's own name is placed first.

All the paired letters residing in the directional houses
Are at that time likewise made into balls of light.

The tenth, king of mantras,
Is written extending through the twelve houses.
The blessing syllable HŪṂ
Adorns each of the four houses at a corner.

Having arranged all this in complete purity,
And having made offerings and torma (ritual cake),
One then proceeds with the transference.

According to each type of activity,
The cloth for the wheel is to be chosen:
For pacifying and enriching,
Use cloth that is especially virtuous in quality.
For subjugating, hooking, procuring, and the like,
And for slaying, separating, repelling,
And suppressing — use charnel-ground cloth.

Camphor and saffron for pacifying and enriching.
Red sandalwood for subjugating and hooking.
Dongro and the like for suppressing.
Crow's blood for repelling.
Mare's milk or buffalo milk for separating.
Poison and so forth for slaying — these are what to write with.

For the virtuous cloth, use good wood.
For the non-virtuous, write with bone,
Iron, and the like.

Pacifying faces east; subjugating faces west.
Enriching faces north; wrathful faces south.
The others are applied as is appropriate.

For pacifying, enriching, subjugating, and hooking,
The earth-circumambulation is arranged in regular sequence,
And the place-circumambulations are written in reverse sequence.
For slaying, repelling, separating, and suppressing,
The earth-circumambulation is written in reverse sequence,
And the sky-circumambulations are written in regular sequence.

If this is not written correctly,
The wheel will turn back upon oneself.

Therefore apply careful attention and do it well.

Once the cloth wheel is properly completed —

The wheel residing in the maṇḍala —

Invite the cloth wheel,

And through the practice of vajra-gathering,

Draw the maṇḍala wheel in.

After making offerings to the cloth wheel,

Meditate with the blessing of truth.

In accordance with the ritual procedure as taught,

Having transferred the wheel,

Begin the recitation of the secret mantras.

Oṃ vajra samaya stvaṃ — this is the samaya mantra.

Oṃ vajra vega hūṃ — this is the mantra of vajra force.

Oṃ asame trisame mahāsamaye svāhā — this is the mantra for mixing the syllables.

Oṃ vajra samājaḥ — this is the mantra for transferring the wheel.

Oṃ yamārāja sadomeyā yamedo ruṇa yodayā yadayoni rayakṣeya yakṣeyaccha nirāmaya phaṭ phaṭ — this is the root secret mantra, accomplishing all activities.

Oṃ hrīḥ ṣṭrīḥ vikṛtanana hūṃ phaṭ — this is the activity secret mantra, accomplishing all activities.

Śāntiṃ kuru svāhā — for prompting pacification.

Puṣṭiṃ kuru svāhā — for enriching.

Vaśaṃ kuru svāhā — for subjugating.

Mārayā phaṭ — for slaying.

Vidveṣayā phaṭ — for separating.

Ucchaṭayā phaṭ — for repelling.

Stambhaya hūṃ laṃ — for suppressing.

Ākarṣaya hūṃ jaḥ — for hooking.

Oṃ muṃḥ — for liberation in return.

The city of Ālī and Kālī

Is the root from which secret mantras arise,

And is also the prison of activity.

If the syllables are not gathered properly,

The sound of the secret mantra will be inverted.

If the syllables are not set out completely,
The sound of the secret mantra will be defective.
If the secret mantra is not recited with the correct signals,
The mantra will yield no spiritual attainment.
If the alignments are not made correctly,
It will utterly fail to become a turning.
If the mixing of syllables is not done,
The sixteen chambers will be without purpose.
If the direction of circumambulation is reversed, the aim will not be accomplished.
A vidyā mantra that is defective or inverted
Is like an asura defeated in battle,
Or like an enemy slain by the enemy of Indra.
If the wheel is not transferred,
The ritual procedures will be defective.
It is accomplished through its being a cause, through practice,
And through firm faith.
Therefore apply earnest effort and carry it out.

This is the first elaborated tantra on the ritual for drawing the wheel of the glorious black wrathful Yamāntaka.

Then, furthermore, what is to be explained:
What the mantra practitioner should always make use of —
What is called tortoise milk,
As well as radiance-leaves,
The moisture of moist earth when dry,
Likewise the exudate of fire,
And the substances of an echo —
If one always makes use of these,
One will by nature be free from illness,
Live long, with the faculties fully flourishing,
And be ever in the full bloom of youth.
All the gods will bestow their blessing.
One should not analyze this —
It is accomplished through its power and through its very nature.
When blessed by meditative absorption and mantra,
It purifies the karmic maturation of actions.

One dwells on the ground of one who holds the vidyā.

Therefore make use of these in accordance with the ritual.

On the first day of the lunar month, just at the break of dawn,

Without touching any vessel, take tortoise yoghurt.

Drink it while still warm,

Or drink it through the aperture of the sun.

On the first day of the waning fortnight,

Having sought out radiance-leaves,

And having held them from that very moment,

After three days, when dawn has broken,

Take those leaves and eat them pressed together.

Or do it through the aperture of the sun.

Having prepared fine clay,

Soak it in water for three days.

Take it out and dry it again,

Then grind it to the measure of a cat's paw-print.

Mix it with cow's milk,

And the mantra practitioner should drink it always.

The young shoot of a fire-tree,

Rolled in earth-butter,

Placed in a sealed vessel,

Pressed with fire, water, and earth —

Drink it, or drink it through the aperture of the sun.

From an echo that is free of saline resonance,

The mantra practitioner should take, at midnight,

The echo-substance bound for three days —

Place it in a vessel in three portions for three days.

The tip portion serves as ointment,

The middle portion is the nectar,

The root portion is to be discarded.

When these are used separately,

At the end, mix with a powder of the three fruits,

One measure of a cat's paw-print each.

Even if not mixed, there is no fault.

Used together, it is said to be excellent.

Used individually as well, there is no fault.

This concludes the second chapter of the liturgical procedure of the Mañjuśrī tantra — the chapter on transforming sacred substances into medicine and presenting them.

Then, furthermore, it is taught:

The distinctions of the activities' auxiliaries —

The pacifying activity is the moon,

The enriching likewise is proclaimed as the eye.

That called "differentiation" pertains to qualities.

The subjugating activity is the Veda.

The hooking activity is likewise the arrow.

Expelling and suppressing are the sense faculties.

Following upon suppression,

The killing activity is held to be the ocean.

Each of these activities, one by one —

The first day: offerings to the noble ones (āryas) and fire-offerings;

The second day: give tormas offerings;

The third day: apply oneself fully to recitation;

The fourth day: complete the fire sacrifice;

The fifth day: turn the activity wheel;

The sixth day: rest in single-pointed meditative concentration;

The seventh day: make up any deficiencies in the activity.

Especially with regard to the activities of the auxiliaries,

For the chief of the activities — whatever one is accomplishing —

Turn the wheel for four days.

If one knows these distinctions of activity,

Pacifying protects from the eight fears;

Enriching connects one with the six qualities;

Subjugating transforms devotion into its four forms;

Differentiating separates out the eight classes of secrets;

Suppressing binds the six sense faculties.

The others are to be understood accordingly.

When one examines the union of mantra and substance,

Attainment is not accomplished through analytical scrutiny.

If doubt arises or deliberation sets in,

Or if faith becomes impaired —

Then even an attainment that is near at hand

Will without doubt turn back.

When one accomplishes with firm faith,
Even if the sky were to cease to exist,
The attainment of mantra cannot fail to occur.
If the knowledge-mantras (vidyā-mantras) taught by gods and sages
Are not deceived,
Then the union of secret mantras taught by one free of attachment
Has not deceived, does not deceive, and will not deceive.

For the wise one who has no doubt about the meaning that is the nature of reality, inconceivable and beyond thought, attainment is close. Or if a simple person has firm faith, attainment through practice is likewise close. For the logician who reasons and analyses, attainment through practice is far. Even if the guru has given the pith instructions, if the student harbors doubt, attainment is said to be far. Even if the guru has kept the pith instructions hidden, if the student harbors no doubt and holds the guru's sacred pith instructions as precious and cherished, success is certain.

For this reason, the mantra practitioner, in order to abandon doubt in their own mind, must above all please the guru. When one has served and honored the guru, their power becomes great. Guarding it in secrecy, proclaiming it without interruption. Having offered great gifts, one's own mind transforms into the two jewels. From those two jewels, accomplishment arises. Having become rare, offer praise. When praise is given, qualities arise. But if one does not offer praise, then just as a wish-fulfilling jewel will not grant desired aims to one who has not praised it, it withholds what is sought.

Faith in the buddha, faith in the Dharma,
Faith in the Saṅgha, faith in the mother,
Faith in the guru, faith in the father,
Faith in the great path, faith in the boat,
Faith is the wish-fulfilling jewel,
Faith is the very attainment of secret mantra,
Faith is the wealth of merit.
Therefore the mantra practitioner,
In order to cultivate faith in their own mind,
Should honor others with reverence as supreme.

From the liturgy for turning the wheel of the black Yamāntaka of glorious Yamārāja — the chapter on activities.

Translator's Notes

- The names Bāro Phyagdum and Vajragrāpha (Rdo rje grags) are Tibetan-era translator names; "Bāro Phyagdum" literally means "Bāro Armless" or "Bāro with a shortened arm," which is unusual for a paṇḍita epithet and may be a nickname or descriptor. This has been rendered as "Bāro Phyagdum" without alteration.

The highly technical maṇḍala-construction instructions in the latter portion of this passage involve specialized astronomical and liturgical terminology, particularly the system of correlating Tibetan calendar signs such as moon, eye, ocean, planet, arrow, and so forth with numerical values for calculating auspicious dates. This is a well-known Indic symbolic numeral system. The term rendered "eye-space" refers to a unit of measurement approximately equal to a finger-breadth used in ritual drawing.

The passage ends mid-sentence, suggesting the text continues beyond the excerpt provided.

- The passage belongs to a maṇḍala or ritual-wheel (cakra) construction manual within the Vajrayāna tradition, detailing the precise placement of syllables, vowels, mantras, and substances for different ritual activities (pacifying, enriching, subjugating, and wrathful or destructive rites). Several highly technical terms (such as "brahma-line," "date-sign house," "limbed-sign house," "ocean-sign house") are technical designations from Tibetan astrological and ritual grid systems; their exact referents depend on the specific ritual-diagram tradition in question, and the renderings given here follow the most natural reading of the Tibetan.

The syllables OM̐, HŪM̐, PHAṬ, JAḤ, SVĀ, LAM̐, and BHĀ are kept in their conventional transliterated forms as standard mantra-syllables that are not translated.

The phrase rendered "the tenth, king of mantras" likely refers to a specific mantra counted as the tenth in a preceding enumeration not visible in this passage; this is noted for context.

- The phrase "the aperture of the sun" likely refers to a lens or glass vessel used to focus sunlight for warming or solar-infusion purposes, a technique referenced in some tantric medical contexts. The precise meaning is not wholly transparent and may reflect a specific ritual-technical idiom.

"Ālī and Kālī" refers to the vowels and consonants of the Sanskrit alphabet respectively, which together constitute the "city" from which all mantras are built. This is standard tantric linguistic doctrine.

"Echo-substance" and "radiance-leaves" are unusual material items in this list of magical-medicinal substances. "Radiance-leaves" may refer to a specific plant known for luminous or shimmering qualities. "Echo-substance" is a genuinely enigmatic term, possibly referring to a substance gathered in a particular resonant location or prepared through a ritual involving sound. These are not standard pharmacological terms and their precise referents are uncertain.

The mantra strings are transliterated as they appear in the Tibetan phonetic rendering; they are not emended.

- The section listing "the first day, the second day" and so on through "the seventh day" reads more like a structured liturgical schedule than verse in the strict sense; it is rendered as verse to match the Tibetan metrical form.

The phrase rendered "the eye" for the enriching activity and "the Veda" for subjugating, and "the arrow" for hooking, and "the sense faculties" for expelling and suppressing, and "the ocean" for killing, all appear to be correlative symbols within a specific ritual-cosmological schema whose full explanatory context is not present in this passage. They are translated

literally as the text gives them; the underlying symbolic correspondences belong to the tradition's oral commentary.

The closing colophon names the source text as the ritual cycle of the wrathful black Yamāntaka associated with Yamārāja (Śrī Kṛṣṇa-Yamāri-cakra-pūjā or equivalent), and the chapter division as pertaining to "activities" (las).

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.